

CivicView Identity Model

Three-tier authentication, lifecycle transitions, and the role of ID.me + FEC/SOS verification in the post-Phase-3 platform.

Owner: Jeffrey Nuez | Status: Phase 3 (Candidate auth) shipped; Phase 4+ pending against this spec

Summary

CivicView supports three independent account types, each with its own session cookie and signed-token salt: **Citizens**, **Candidates**, and **Representatives**. The three identities can coexist in the same browser at the transport layer; the frontend enforces one active role at a time. Engagement capability is tiered by verification + subscription state, not by account type alone. Candidates who win elections are promoted in place to representatives, preserving their history and follower base.

This document is the source of truth for how identity, verification, and lifecycle work in the platform. Implementation phases reference back to it; deviations require updating this spec first.

Engagement Tiers

Reading and navigation are free for everyone. Higher-friction engagement is gated to higher-trust verification states. The ladder maps abuse-surface risk to the cost the user has paid to participate.

Tier	Who	What they can do	Gate
0 — Anonymous	Anyone on the internet	Read posts, polls, comments. Browse reps, candidates, bills, votes, executive orders	None
1 — Verified Citizen	Real person, ID.me-confirmed	Everything in Tier 0, plus: like / dislike posts and comments, verification (free) + can	ID.me identity verification (free)
2 — Subscribed Citizen	Tier-1 citizen with an active CivicView subscription	Everything in Tier 1, plus: post comments and replies, active polls, subscription-auth	Replies, active polls, subscription

Rationale: like / dislike / vote are quantitative signals with low abuse surface, so they unlock at Tier 1 with no subscription friction. Comments and polls are text-based and high-abuse-surface, so the Tier-2 subscription gate doubles as a moderation signal and a revenue source.

Account Types

Three independent account tables, one cookie per account type. The same human can hold accounts in multiple tables (e.g. a sitting rep who is also a citizen who comments on other reps' pages). The frontend enforces one active role per browser session by tearing down the other two on each login.

Citizen accounts (citizen_accounts)

- Created via the public signup flow or the demo-citizen self-serve endpoint.
- Verified via ID.me (post-Phase 3 — currently demo accounts are unverified=False).

- Carry geography (state, congressional district, city) used for scope-filtering engagement.
- Cookie: `cl_citizen`. Bearer header: `X-Citizen-Token`.

Candidate accounts (`candidate_accounts`)

- Created when a person legally on a ballot claims their candidate page through the verification flow.
- Keyed on `candidate_id` (e.g. `fl-cand-byron-donalds`), matched 1:1 to a row in the curated candidate registry.
- Lifecycle: pending at create time, flipped to active by admin (Phase 1-3) or automatically by ID.me + FEC/SOS data match (Phase 5+).
- Cookie: `cl_candidate`. Bearer header: `X-Candidate-Token`.

Representative accounts (`rep_accounts`)

- Created for sitting reps (House, Senate, executive officials, state-level, local) when they claim their official page. Currently provisioned by admin onboarding; future state uses the `.gov`-email verification path or a Congressional digital affairs partnership.
- Keyed on `official_id` (`bioguide_id` for federal, state-seeded ids for state/local).
- Cookie: `cl_session`. Bearer header: `Authorization: Bearer ...`

Capabilities by Account Type

Action	Tier-1 Citizen	Tier-2 Citizen	Candidate	Representative
Read posts / polls / comments	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Like / dislike posts	Yes	Yes	On own page only	On own page only
Vote on polls	Yes	Yes	On own page only	On own page only
Comment on posts	—	Yes	On own page only	On own page only
Reply to top-level comments	—	If original commenter	On own page only	On own page only
Create standalone polls	—	On unclaimed rep page	On own page only	Not applicable (use posts)
Post on a page	—	—	Own candidate page	Own rep page
Manage page dashboard	—	—	Yes (own page)	Yes (own page)
Delete own posts / polls / comments	Own comments only	Own comments + polls	Own content on own page	Own content on own page

Reps and candidates engaging with their *own* content (Phase 2 self-engagement) record an `author_rep_id` / `author_candidate_id` on the reaction / comment row. The UI surfaces an “Author” badge on those rows so other viewers see the page owner’s voice distinctly. Self-engagement does not extend across pages — a rep visiting a peer’s page falls through to the standard citizen path.

Verification Model

Identity (who you are) and **role authority** (what you’re entitled to claim) are two separate questions. ID.me answers the first; FEC, Secretary of State filings, and admin review answer the second.

Citizens

ID.me confirms the person is real and lives at the address they claim. The verified geography flows into their `CitizenAccount` row (state / congressional_district / city) and drives engagement scope filtering. Today the platform runs demo citizens with `verified=False`; ID.me integration (Phase 5+) flips the flag and unlocks Tier-1 capabilities.

Candidates

Two factors required: **ID.me** (identity) + a **candidacy data match** (entitlement). Auto-approval path:

- ID.me name + DOB + address match a current FEC filing (federal candidates) → auto-approve.
- ID.me match against a state Secretary of State ballot filing (state + local) → auto-approve.
- Party nomination paperwork on file (primary winners awaiting general election) → auto-approve.
- Anything else (write-ins, declared-but-not-filed, edge cases) → admin review queue.

All Phase 1-3 claims today go through manual admin review — the auto-approve path is Phase 5+ work.

Representatives

Two factors required: **ID.me** (identity) + proof the person represents the claimed office. Acceptable proofs:

- Verification email sent to the rep's official .gov address.
- Long-term: partnership with the House / Senate Digital Affairs office for batch verification.
- Today: manual admin onboarding (the current path).

Lifecycle Transitions

The same human moves through political life: citizen, then candidate, then representative, then (sometimes) back to citizen after defeat or retirement. The platform models these transitions explicitly so history, followers, and accountability records carry forward correctly.

Citizen → Candidate

- An ID.me-verified citizen who is legally on a ballot may claim their candidate page.
- The claim creates a CandidateAccount with `claim_status='pending'`. The citizen's existing CitizenAccount remains active and separate — the same person now holds two independent accounts.
- Verification (auto via FEC/SOS match, or manual admin review) flips the candidate account to `active`. The candidate can then sign in via the candidate login.

Candidate → Representative (election win)

Decision: Promote in place. The candidate account itself transitions to a representative account rather than being deleted and recreated. Concretely:

- The CandidateAccount's historical content (posts, polls, comments) carries forward to the new rep page — the same author identity is preserved through a foreign-key remap or a role flag.
- Followers from the campaign page automatically follow the rep page.
- The candidate's sign-in continues to work; on next login they land on the rep dashboard.
- Implementation detail (Phase 6+): either flip a `role` column on a unified account record, OR keep the candidate account locked-historical and create a linked rep account with `former_candidate_id` FK. The user experience is identical; the choice is between schema simplicity and audit-trail explicitness.

Defeated rep / defeated candidate

Decision: Archive to read-only public; owner keeps read access. The page stays publicly viewable forever — civic memory matters for accountability around past statements and votes. The former rep or candidate:

- Cannot post, poll, comment, or moderate from the archived page.
- Can still log in to view their own dashboard analytics (their term's engagement history).
- Retains any separate citizen account they hold — defeat doesn't affect citizen-tier capabilities.
- May reactivate as a candidate in a future cycle (admin-approved unarchive, reusing the same account).

Incumbents running for re-election

Incumbents do **not** get a parallel candidate page during their re-election campaign. Their existing rep page is their campaign presence. Challengers get candidate pages until the election resolves; if a challenger wins, the incumbent's rep page archives and the challenger's candidate page promotes to the rep page.

Resignation, death, or mid-term vacancy

The rep page archives immediately. A special election process determines the replacement, which moves through the standard candidate → rep flow.

Cross-Identity Rules

Same human, multiple accounts

Reps and candidates are humans who also happen to be citizens. A sitting rep can plausibly hold **all three** account types at once: their rep account for the office they currently hold, a candidate account for a different office they're running for, and a citizen account for engaging on other reps' pages. The platform supports this triple-identity case explicitly.

- **Rep account** — for managing the page of their current office, posting, dashboard analytics.
- **Candidate account** — required *only* when running for a *different* office than the one they currently hold (e.g. a House rep running for Senate or Governor, a state legislator running for U.S. House). Incumbents running for *re-election* to the same office use their existing rep page as their campaign presence — no parallel candidate account is created in that case (see Lifecycle Transitions for the full rule).
- **Citizen account** — for engaging on *other* reps' pages as a constituent, voting in their own district's polls, commenting on bills or executive orders that affect them personally. Requires ID.me verification like any other citizen.

The three account tables each have independent email uniqueness, so the same email address may be used across all three. This is intentional — same person, separate identities serving separate purposes. When the rep wins the new office they're running for, the candidate account promotes to a new rep account (per the Candidate → Representative flow), and their *previous* rep page archives to read-only public — they now hold the new rep account plus their citizen account, with the former rep page preserved as historical record.

Session mutual exclusivity

The backend permits all three session cookies simultaneously, but the frontend enforces “one active role per browser” by tearing down the other two on each login. This avoids visual ambiguity (a single identity pill in the navbar, one dashboard surface) at the cost of forcing a sign-out + sign-in switch between roles. Users who need parallel sessions can use a second browser or incognito tab.

Implementation: `_tearDownTwoOtherRoles` in `lib/pagesApi.js` fires both other-role logout endpoints in parallel before minting the new session.

Engagement attribution

Each engagement row (reaction, comment, vote) records exactly one of: `citizen_id`, `author_rep_id`, `author_candidate_id` — never two at once. The XOR is enforced at the route layer (`_resolve_engager` helper) rather than via a database CHECK, since SQLite can't cleanly enforce cross-column constraints.

Open Questions & Phase Plan

Items deferred from the current spec for explicit decision in later phases:

- **Promotion mechanism — in-place flip vs lock+relink.** Both preserve user experience. Decision deferred until we ship the first candidate-wins-election flow (Phase 6+). Audit-trail vs schema-simplicity tradeoff.
- **Subscription pricing + payment integration.** The Tier 0/1/2 ladder is locked, but the price point and billing provider (Stripe, Paddle, etc.) are open. Phase 5 polish.

- **Account linking for the same human across roles.** Should an ID.me-verified person who has both a citizen account and a rep account get them linked behind the scenes? Useful for abuse-prevention audits; orthogonal to UX. Decision punted to post-launch.
- **Reactivation of dormant accounts.** A defeated candidate or rep running again 2-4 years later — do they reactivate their old account or create a new one? Likely “reactivate, preserving the archived page as historical.” Phase 7+ once we have actual repeat candidates.
- **Specific .gov-email verification flow for reps.** The high-level model is settled, the concrete email verification template + bounce handling is a Phase 5 implementation item.

Implementation Status

Phase	Scope	Status
Self-engagement Phase 1	Citizen Author badge on own polls	Shipped
Self-engagement Phase 2	Reps engage as page owners (likes, votes, comments)	Shipped
Self-engagement Phase 3	Reply threading + two-party rule	Shipped
Candidate Phase 1	Read-only candidate connectivity	Shipped
Candidate Phase 2	CandidateAccount model + admin surfaces	Shipped
Candidate Phase 3	Candidate auth + login modal	Shipped
Candidate Phase 4	Candidate page composer + dashboard	In progress
Candidate Phase 5	Notifications + polish + help-build update	Pending
Phase 6+	ID.me integration + FEC/SOS auto-approval + subscription billing	Future
Phase 7+	Election-win promotion flow + defeated-account archival	Future

— End of spec —